

Switching allegiances: Despite being born and raised in England, Hamza Choudhury (centre) represents Bangladesh at the international level.

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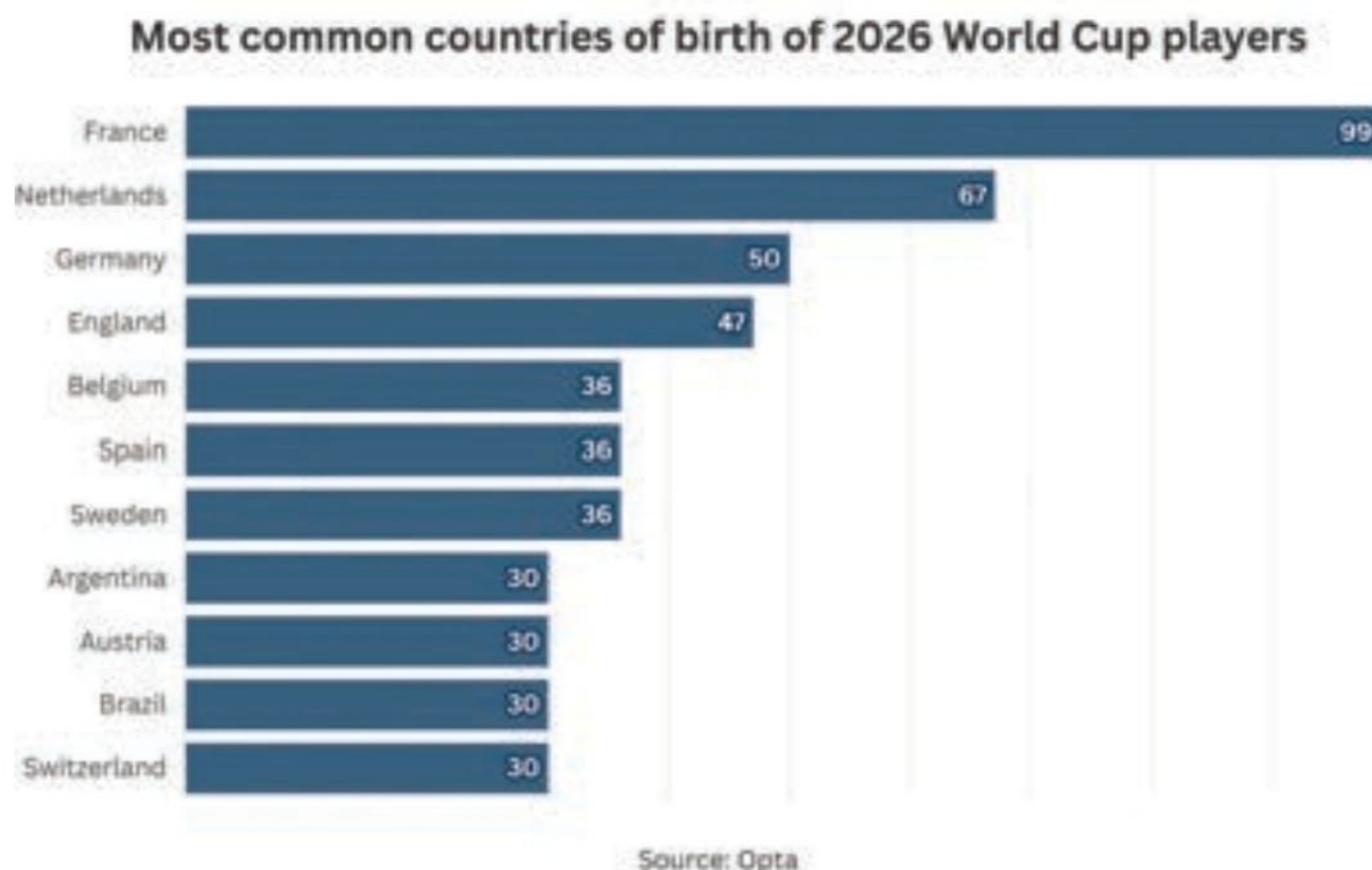
But there has also been criticism from certain quarters, whether driven by racism or other concerns.

Former FIFA president Sepp Blatter warned in 2007 that naturalisation could lead to an “invasion” of Brazilian players across several national teams.

At this World Cup, however, only four Brazil-born players represented other countries — far from the scenario he feared.

Ahead of the World Cup semifinal between France and Spain, former Spanish Prime Minister Mariano Rajoy criticised Les Bleus for fielding too many players of foreign heritage, writing: “... one thing they don't have is any French players.” In reality, 23 of France's 26-man squad were born in the country.

France has, in fact, not only nurtured players for its own national team but also for several others that featured at this World Cup. According to Opta, 99 of the tournament's 1,248



players were born in France.

What's in it for India?

There is a broader subplot here, especially for India, whose FIFA ranking and international performances have stagnated over the past three years.

The country has a stringent policy against dual citizenship and allows players to represent India only after surrendering their previous passport, unlike neighbouring nations such as Bangladesh and Pakistan.

While Bangladesh welcomed Hamza Choudhury into its national team last year, Pakistan brought Easah Suliman into its senior side. Both were born and raised in England and had represented the Three Lions at age-group level.

Morocco, however, offers perhaps the strongest case study. The African nation reached a historic semifinal in Qatar 2022 before advancing to the quarterfinals this time, with several players coming from its diaspora.

